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MVP meeting of the minds

Invited heatherhannan33@gmail.com Miguel Alvarado gregpharris@gmail.com Miguel Alvarado

Attachments MVP meeting of the minds

Meeting records Transcript

Summary

The team met to establish formal project management, define product scope, and coordinate future development cadence.

Defining App Scope Strategy
The team prioritized a minimal, spatial user interface over content-heavy feeds to facilitate intentional parenting. They identified the need for a multi-agent system to manage distinct, age-appropriate family interactions.

Formalizing Project Management Tools
To improve development efficiency, the team moved away from organic documentation by adopting centralized folders and design software. This shift aims to standardize feedback loops before the upcoming beta launch.

Establishing Recurring Development Cadence
The participants finalized a recurring weekly meeting schedule to ensure consistent strategic alignment. Maintaining a focused product scope remains the primary priority to ensure a successful initial launch.

Rate this Summary: Helpful or Not Helpful

Decisions

NEEDS FURTHER DISCUSSION

- **Children's AI agent feature strategy** The project requires further alignment on the specific purpose, safety standards, and appropriate age-based interface design for the proposed AI agent feature for children.

ALIGNED

- **Family and child agent architecture defined** The product architecture will feature a main family agent for parents alongside separate, age-appropriate agents for individual children to facilitate safe handoffs.
- **Shared workspace and design tools selected** The team will utilize a shared Google Drive for documentation and product backlogs, while Figma will serve as the primary environment for design collaboration.
- **Tablet support added to device strategy** The product strategy will include support for tablets alongside phones to facilitate safe technology handoffs from parents to children.
- **Beta launch milestone set for fall** The development timeline is set to target a beta release for initial user testing by the start of the next school year this fall.
- **Figma adoption for collaboration** The team aligned on using Figma as the centralized platform for design collaboration and engineering handoff for the product.
- **Core product focus and team size** The project strategy is set to maintain a small project group and prioritize the core product to ensure the defined market niche is successfully addressed.

We've **updated the Decisions section** using your feedback.

Let us know what you think: Helpful or Not Helpful

Next steps

- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer] Research homeschooling demographics: Gather market data and insights regarding the growth and needs of homeschooling families to inform product strategy.
- [ ] [Miguel Alvarado] Setup Project Workspace: Establish a Google Drive folder for shared project documentation. Include existing materials and create an initial product backlog spreadsheet.
- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer] Share Farming Resources: Send text messages to Greg containing details on the Ecology Center and other agricultural business models.
- [ ] [Greg Harris] Research Wendelberry: Investigate the background and agricultural concepts associated with the mentioned individual.
- [ ] [Greg Harris] Share project spec: Finish drafting the project specification and share it to provide insight into the upcoming journal features and scheduling capabilities.
- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer] Study UI flows: Review the Mobin design resource to study user interface flows and onboarding patterns for the beta launch.
- [ ] [Greg Harris] Create Figma Project: Create a new project workspace in Figma for the MVP and share access with the team.
- [ ] [Greg Harris] Document User Journeys: Upload screen grabs from the current test flight version into the Figma file and annotate user journeys to highlight design improvements.
- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer] Share Personas: Share the existing audience persona research with Greg Harris for review.
- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer, Greg Harris] Exchange Contact Details: Send professional contact information and supplementary resources to each other via text and email.
- [ ] [Heather Hannan-Kramer, Greg Harris] Schedule Follow-up Meeting: Attend a follow-up meeting on Thursday at 9:00 a.m. to discuss aesthetic design and product development progress.
- [ ] [Greg Harris] Send Decks: Share the Happily project files with Heather for review.
- [ ] [The group] Utilize Figma: Conduct design tasks within this software to ensure alignment on the core product.

- [ ] [The group] Manage Alignment: Keep Miguel concentrated on primary development objectives instead of secondary features.

Details

- **Introductions and Collaboration**: Miguel, Heather, and Greg meet to discuss their collaborative project, with Heather and Miguel providing background on their previous work and current motivations for pursuing the app development . They note that their respective professional situations have provided them with more time to dedicate to this collaboration .
- **Project Genesis**: Heather explains the history of their project, noting that an initial attempt to launch a parenting app was stalled by the pandemic (00:03:45). They are now leveraging their combined experiences—Miguel as a single father of two and Heather as a parent and consultant—to restart development with a new focus (00:04:44).
- **Design Aesthetics**: Heather and Greg analyze the design preferences of different generations, agreeing that while Gen X and Millennials have similar aesthetic values, Gen Z prefers bolder, more visual content (00:05:44). Greg emphasizes that the application's aesthetic must align with the specific purpose of the interaction, such as mindfulness versus entertainment, rather than just general market trends .
- **UI and User Experience**: Greg argues against a feed-based, content-heavy interface like those found in apps such as TikTok, suggesting instead that their parenting app should be spatial and minimal to encourage "lean-in," thoughtful engagement . Heather agrees that the app should facilitate intentional use, especially given the limited time pockets parents have .
- **AI Design Pitfalls**: Miguel and Greg discuss the negative impact of overusing emojis in AI-generated designs, noting that such approaches often result in a poor user experience that does not resonate with an adult audience (00:12:04).
- **Target Demographic**: The group confirms that the target audience is parents of young children. Greg mentions that his own life stage, which includes grandchildren, offers him a "wise owl" perspective on the various stages of parenting .

- **Agent Architecture and Handoff**: Greg highlights the potential of the "handoff" feature, where parents set up an environment on a device to share with their children (00:14:36). He suggests that the app needs a multi-agent system where a "master" family agent can manage distinct, age-appropriate agents for different children .
- **Calendar and Content Automation**: Heather proposes a "plugin" feature for calendar extraction and population, similar to the email-managing app Superhuman, to help parents organize after-school activities and camps . Miguel adds that the AI agent should go beyond organization to proactively suggest activities based on the family's profile (00:20:28).
- **Parallels to Farming**: Greg shares details about a separate project he is developing: a farm journal and planning app . He notes that the cyclical nature of managing a farm, including infrastructure, budget, and task scheduling, shares many parallels with the planning needs of parents .
- **Homeschooling Market Opportunity**: Greg notes that homeschoolers represent a significant, distinct demographic—approximately 25% in his area—who actively seek resources and group activities, presenting a potential market opportunity for the app .
- **Commitment to Collaboration**: Greg confirms his commitment to the project, expressing specific interest in the companion agent architecture and the handoff functionality .
- **Development Documentation and Backlog**: Miguel describes the current development process as organic, relying on Markdown files to track changes . The group decides to establish a Google Drive folder and a formal product backlog to move from an organic, informal process to a structured project management approach .
- **Technical Infrastructure and Tools**: Regarding design collaboration, Greg notes that while he uses Figma, they need to determine the best way to share and provide feedback (00:38:28). They agree to use the shared Google Drive folder for artifacts initially (00:39:20).
- **Device Strategy**: The team agrees that while the current focus is mobile, an iPad-based experience is important for the "handoff" feature, as many parents prefer to give tablets rather than phones to their children .

- **Beta Launch Strategy**: Heather outlines a goal to create a functional beta version by the next school year, targeting 25 to 50 users in their immediate circles to gather feedback and demonstrate the concept to potential investors (00:42:54).
- **Go-to-Market Strategy**: The group acknowledges that a separate go-to-market strategy, covering social media, advertising, and user acquisition, will be required for growth, even though they are currently prioritizing core product development .
- **Agentic AI Landscape**: Miguel and Heather identify that while "agentic AI" has succeeded in the enterprise sector, there is an untapped opportunity for consumer-facing agentic AI, specifically in the parenting space .
- **Competitive Analysis**: Heather critiques an existing competitor, "Bumo/Benny," noting that their user experience is poor and their feature set fails to solve the actual needs of parents .
- **Community and Sustainability**: In a concluding discussion, the participants reflect on the socio-economic impacts of economic influx on local farming communities and the rise of agro-tourism, drawing parallels between these issues and their desire to build a responsible, community-focused platform .
- **Greg's Agro-tourism Farm Concept**: Greg is developing an agro-tourism business that focuses on providing seasonal farm experiences for visitors, intentionally moving away from the traditional CSA model of delivering produce boxes. They intend to leverage their and their spouse's professional photography backgrounds to transform the farm into a visually appealing backdrop for art, photography tours, and workshops, aiming to create a place that remains engaging throughout the year (00:57:39).
- **Inspiration for the Farm Concept**: Heather suggests that Greg look at existing models like Full Belly Farm and The Ecology Center in San Juan Capistrano, which successfully integrate education, dining, and aesthetic branding. They also discuss Charlotte Knox's farm in Sebastopol, which uses music series to bring the community together and solve the challenge of seasonal revenue fluctuations (00:59:38) (01:01:07).
- **Logistics and Future Growth**: Greg acknowledges that hosting events comes with significant logistical hurdles, including the need for specialized permits, water access, and parking management (01:01:07). They hope to scale from small gatherings of 10 to 50 people to larger events within three to five years, once the farm has matured beyond its current state of "dirt and baby plants" (01:02:41).

- **MVP App Concept and Origin**: Heather explains that the app, titled "Most Valuable Parent," was born from a desire to provide a supportive, community-driven tool for parents, emphasizing the "mom next door" connection over clinical advice (01:06:37) (01:08:25). The project aims to combat the isolation of parenting by facilitating real-time connections and providing a more accessible experience than clinical alternatives, such as the app created by Dr. Becky (01:09:27) (01:14:30).
- **App Design and Aesthetic**: Heather emphasizes that the app's success depends on a high-quality, welcoming design that appeals to millennials and Gen Z, who prioritize aesthetic experience (01:18:17). They want the interface to feel conversational and soothing, ensuring that users feel good while using the tool, rather than feeling pressured or overwhelmed by a clinical interface (01:09:27) (01:14:30).
- **Functionality and Engagement**: Regarding the beta launch, Heather argues for an approach of being "just enough to be dangerous," meaning they should build a smooth, hooking user experience that demonstrates the app's primary value without requiring it to be fully feature-complete. Greg agrees, noting that achieving the "one-two step" on every touchpoint is critical to capturing user interest (01:19:06).
- **Onboarding Strategy**: Greg stresses the importance of a seamless, low-friction onboarding process, citing their experience with WeTransfer, which became successful by focusing on a single, simple action (01:21:55). They agree that trying to gather too much user information upfront is a common failure point and suggest a "drip" approach where information is collected gradually (01:20:47) (01:27:16).
- **Design and Prototyping Tools**: To refine the app's design, Greg recommends using Mobin, a screenshot gallery of popular user interfaces, as a reference for current trends (01:24:58). They plan to use Figma for design collaboration, as it is a standard tool for engineering handoffs, and Greg offers to create a shared project file for the team to use as a space for feedback and iteration (01:26:18) (01:47:15).
- **Potential Senior-Focused App**: During a side discussion, Heather shares their experience with elder care advocacy and notes that many seniors struggle with basic video technology like FaceTime (01:29:17). They brainstorm an idea for a simple, two-button, face-recognition-based communication app for seniors, which they believe could be highly valuable and monetizable (01:30:01).

- **Development of a Children's Agent**: A significant discussion point is the potential for an "agent" feature for children, which Heather suggests should operate on a separate interface, such as a tablet (01:35:29) (01:37:04). Greg highlights the need to balance this with parent concerns about screen time and data security, and they discuss the possibility of creating a "parents away assistant" that could be used by babysitters or grandparents to maintain consistent care (01:39:54) (01:44:02).
- **Future Collaboration and Planning**: Heather and Greg confirm their commitment to continue collaborating, with plans to share pitch decks from previous projects, such as Happily, to provide inspiration (01:44:02). They conclude by agreeing to schedule future design discussions and use shared digital tools to manage the development of the MVP's aesthetic and user flow (01:45:39) (01:51:13).
- **Design Philosophy and User Experience**: Greg Harris argues that functionality, simplicity, and ease of use are more critical than aesthetic branding, citing successful applications like My Fitness Pal, Instagram, Facebook, and Telegram as examples of effective, though not necessarily beautiful, user interfaces (01:54:49). Heather Hannan-Kramer agrees with the necessity of balancing form and function while acknowledging the importance of knowing the target audience (01:55:53).
- **Target Audience and Persona Development**: Greg Harris emphasizes the necessity of identifying specific user personas to inform design decisions, noting that the demographic should be clearly defined, whether Generation X, Generation Z, or other groups. The conversation notes that the current target is not the "boomer" generation. Heather Hannan-Kramer confirms that they have already begun the research process to define these personas and will share the findings with Greg Harris (01:56:36).
- **Meeting Cadence and Scheduling**: Greg Harris and Heather Hannan-Kramer agree to establish a recurring meeting cadence, preferably on Thursday mornings, to coordinate efforts. Greg Harris notes they have a part-time teaching role for a cohort of students in Hjo, China, which will conclude in two weeks, providing more flexibility in their schedule (01:57:39) (01:59:22). They finalize a recurring time slot for Thursdays from 9:00 a.m. to 10:00 a.m (02:00:07).
- **Next Steps and Development Logistics**: Greg Harris commits to setting up a Figma space before the next meeting to document screenshots and map user journeys, particularly focusing on addressing current "dead ends" in the

experience developed by Miguel. This work will serve as a basis for annotating the design in preparation for the beta launch in the fall (02:00:07).

- **Project Momentum and Market Timing**: Heather Hannan-Kramer expresses enthusiasm regarding the project's progress, describing the current phase as a time for gathering momentum (02:01:04). They discuss the current vacuum in the "parent tech" sector and emphasize the importance of striking while the "iron is hot," noting that timing is a critical factor in the success of ventures in Silicon Valley (02:02:39).
- **Lessons from Previous Ventures**: Greg Harris reflects on a past venture called "Happily," explaining that it failed not due to a lack of viability, but because the technology was ahead of its time and funding was exhausted (02:02:39). Greg Harris agrees to share the original pitch decks for "Happily" with Heather Hannan-Kramer to analyze the storytelling approach used in that project (02:03:38).
- **Strategic Focus and Scope Management**: Heather Hannan-Kramer stresses the importance of maintaining a tight, focused scope for the core product rather than attempting to do too many things at once, while ensuring that the necessary plugins function well (02:03:38). They express a need to keep the development team, specifically Miguel, focused on the core vision rather than adding extraneous features (02:04:27). Greg Harris compares this strategy to the phased approach used in their own farming business, noting that focusing on specific goals per year is necessary to prevent project dilution (02:05:06). They confirm the shared goal of staying focused in the Figma space to keep the development direction aligned with the core vision (02:05:46).

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